

Chapter 1

You've Been Lied To

I want to start this chapter out with a few simple questions—questions that you may be asking yourself right now. Is it possible for “the average Joe” to become a millionaire in America today? The news talks a lot about the income gap, saying things like “the little man can’t get ahead” or “the American Dream is dead.” But is that really true? Is the American Dream really dead and gone? Is it available to anyone, or is it something only reserved for other people—rich people? I’ve asked these questions many times, and I’ve struggled because there were things I wanted to achieve, but I just didn’t think it was possible for someone like me. Growing up, I believed millionaires were born into money—and I certainly was not. As a black kid in a single-parent home in Kentucky, I felt like the odds were stacked against me. My family wasn’t poor, but we weren’t wealthy by any means. My mom did an amazing job providing for me and my brother, but there wasn’t a bunch of extra money laying around. Becoming a millionaire seemed like a faraway fantasy, something completely out of reach for me.

Back then, I thought the key to building wealth was to chase after a higher and higher income. I believed that more money coming in would automatically cause me to build wealth. Imagine my surprise when that didn’t happen. The more money I made, in fact, the more things stayed the same. I kept waiting for the next raise, the next promotion—always pinning